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HAMPAGNE IS ONE of the world's most celebrated wines, and it is both deeply understood and widely misunderstood. Of-

ten mistaken for any sparkling wine with a popping cork, you may not realise that a bottle can only be called 'Champagne' if it has been produced in the Champagne region of northeast France.

This comes down to Geographical Indication (GI) laws, a form of protectionism that works like a trademark but goes even further. GIs ensure that certain products can only be made in specific regions. It's common practice across the world of spirits. Even Scotch whisky must be made in Scotland to be called Scotch.

A few years ago, I boarded a train from Paris's Gare du Nord, bound for the heart of Champagne country—Reims and Épernay, the twin capitals of the region. Between them, these two cities produce around 300 million bottles of Champagne each year. Many of the brands we've heard of in India—Moët & Chandon, Veuve Clicquot, Dom Pérignon, and Krug (all conveniently owned by the LVMH conglomerate)—have their vast estates sprawled across acres of meticulously maintained vineyards in this area. Visitors are welcomed and treated to guided tours through these grand maisons, complete with stories of their rich histories, the quirks of Champagne-making, and, of course, tastings of their prized vintages. It was an unforgettable experience.

BEYOND THE BUBBLES

Champagne is traditionally made from a trio of grapes—Chardonnay, Pinot Noir, and Pinot Meunier—grown in the cool, chalky soils of the region. But producers craft 'Blanc de

Blancs' from Chardonnay alone, or 'Blanc de Noirs' using only Pinot Noir or Pinot Meunier, offering even more distinctive expressions.

The rigorous process of making Champagne adds to its mystique. Unlike other wines, Champagne undergoes a complex double-fermentation process, involving multiple intricate steps along the way—blending (assemblage) the right base wines, riddling (remuage) or rotating the bottles to move the sediment to the neck, disgorgement to remove it, followed by adding the precise amount of dosage for the desired sweetness, and finally, a period of ageing to let the magic happen. All this effort means Champagne can never be cheap. Even the most basic bottle costs a significant amount when bought at a wine shop.

Like all wines, Champagne comes down to personal preference. But there's one thing most connoisseurs agree on: the finer, more delicate the bubbles, the better the Champagne. Tiny, persistent bubbles are the hallmark of quality, bringing

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▲ NOT JUST ANY SPARKLING WINE

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